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Martha Liebrum, Editor
The Magazine of
The Houston Post
4747 Southwest Freeway
Houston, Texas 77001

Dear Ms. Liebrum:

I am sending for your consideration a piece for the Essay section of The Magazine. This is an especially enjoyable part of The Post to me and I have appreciated the opportunity to share the experiences which have been written by some of your readers.

Perhaps you will find this essay to be suitable for your use in a future edition.

Yours truly,

Jim Bishop, FAIA

JB:bh
encl.

THE COMMUTER

An Essay by Jim Bishop
206 S. Masonic Street
Bellville, Texas 77418

In the last seven years I have driven approximately 228,000 miles getting to and from my home into Houston where my architectural practice is located. That, I believe, qualifies me as a commuter.

In 1978 my wife and I moved to Bellville to live in a restored victorian home which had been built in 1874. My architectural practice was still very active and having no desire to retire I became a member of that fraternity of souls who brave the highways and freeways between Houston and the surrounding smaller communities each day as they try to combine the advantages of a large city's economy with the slower, laid back life style of a small town.

There are two routes one can take to Bellville from Houston. The most obvious is Interstate 10, better known as the Katy Freeway. It is even better known as the longest parking lot in Texas. You proceed west on I-10 to Sealy then turn north on Highway 36 and twelve miles later you're in Bellville. The other route is a two lane black top farm-to-market road which cuts through the rice fields of western Harris County, the cattle grazing fields of Waller County, crosses the Brazos River and climbs a few hills and thence on into Bellville. Both ways are about 55 miles from west Houston.

Guess which road I travel? I tried the Katy Freeway a few times but it was not a good experience. F.M.529, on the other hand, was a pleasant drive through rural scenery, once one got off of Highway 290.

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The past seven years of travel along the same road has given me an excellent opportunity to observe the growth of this north-western area of Houston. Subdivisions filled with tract housing have replaced many of the rice fields. Quick stop convenience groceries have sprung up on several now major intersections. Gasoline stations have also been built west of Highway 6. A large new high school just opened this fall in what was wide open prairie just 5 years ago. It's named after Langham Creek, a small meandering sandy creek which winds through the countryside out there. Only it isn't countryside any more. It's all new houses and apartments.

When I first started driving this road in 1978, it was great for duck and goose hunting. Now, it's only fair for hunting. The subdivisions have displaced the huge flocks of snow geese and mallards which used to land in the fields to rest and feed. Farther west in Waller County the flocks still come in during November and December, but they seem to be much smaller than in the past.

Hunters still put out their white decoys and huddle under their white sheets, waiting in the misery of the cold and rain watching the geese land over in the field across the road where the Posted, No Hunting signs are nailed to the weathered cedar fence posts. Those geese are smart.

The seasonal changes which nature and the weather bring to the land help to keep my drives from becoming totally boring. If one

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looks for it there is much to be seen and felt as you travel this area.

Spring paints the land with multi-colored clusters of wild flowers. There are spider lilies, coreopsis, sunflowers, black-eyed susan, indian paint brush and small patches of blue bonnets. You have to get west of the Brazos before you see the large fields full of blue bonnets. Terrapins, box turtles, and the big, slow crawling water turtles cross the road going who knows where when the sun begins to warm the ground. They come in all sizes and you have to admire their courage as they dare the odds in getting to the other side. Some of them make it. A few of them don't. Most drivers will swerve to miss them and as the cars and pick-up trucks swish overhead, the turtles tuck in their heads as if that would protect them from the crush of a tire.

In the summer I check the crops. 'See how the rice is sprouting up out of the mud and watch the crop dusters in their ugly looking yellow airplanes as they swoop across the power lines at the side of the road and then drop down to about twenty feet above the ground and start to spray the fields with whatever chemicals they use to make the rice grow or protect it from bugs or something. On occasion I will engage in mock combat with one of the yellow planes as he unsuspectingly crosses my path on the road. I get him in my sights and press the firing button on my steering wheel and send a burst of machine gun fire into his tail and rudder. He goes down in a trail

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of pesticide. Take that Yellow Baron.

Early October mornings are a special treat as I am driving eastward into the sun toward the city. The shadows are long and provide dark backdrops for the orange rays of sun as they reflect off of hundreds of delicate ground spider webs. The webs are coated with dew which sparkles and glistens in the sun. The webs are everywhere, in the grass, between strands of barbed wire, from the fence posts to the wire, and between clumps of underbrush along the roadside. Tiny creatures, each one weaving an incredible masterpiece.

By November the hawks that stay here all year long are joined by their relatives from the northern U.S. and Canada. Big red-tails begin to roost on the power lines and poles, looking for a meal in the fallow rice fields. A nice plump field mouse or a rabbit will do nicely, thank you. Marsh hawks, Kestrels and other species come through here on their way into Mexico. Some will stay here for the winter, sitting up on their perches patiently watching the moving cars and trucks which invade their territory. They never flock together and seldom do I ever see them even in pairs. They seem to lead a lonely life, intent only on searching for their next prey. They have been called "winged executioners" because once a hawk spots its prey and swoops after it, the prey seldom escapes. Sadly, on occasion, I will see the remains of a hawk in the road, the victim of his intensity of the hunt and it has fallen after being hit by a motorist. A sad end to one of nature's fearless creatures.

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Winter along the road is probably the least interesting time of the year. The winter rains sometimes fill the fields and roadside ditches and will cover the road at several of the usual low-lying areas. The always muddy Brazos will rise and fall, depending upon how much rain has fallen up to the north.

Loose livestock along the road is an ever-present danger. Cattle and horses from time to time find their way through a fence or across a cattle guard and will graze along the road, usually ignoring the traffic which is passing by. It's a good idea however to slow down as you approach them as they will sometimes bolt unexpectedly across your path or stop in front of you and give you a look as if to say, "What is your hurry, Mister?" Deer are also visible along the road as they graze in the grass or nibble on the lower leaves of small trees. Driving the road at night calls for extreme caution as black angus cattle are impossible to see until you are too close to stop. I haven't hit any yet, but I've had two near misses. My only collision with an animal so far has been when a large buck deer ran into the side of my car one evening just before sunset. I saw him at the side of the road just as he came out of the edge of the woods. I slowed and waited to see what he would do. He looked at me and stood as if he would also wait for me so I began to accelerate and as I did he bolted and jumped the barbed wire fence. He hit the right rear fender a glancing blow. I looked back in my rear view mirror as he shook himself and trotted on across the road. He cleared the fence

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easily and disappeared into the woods.

Whenever anyone finds out the fact that I commute about a hundred and ten miles every day they usually say, "How can you stand it? It must be terribly boring." I just smile and reply, "It's worth every mile."

END